

SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Ministries Departments and Central Secretariat - Learner-v2 Refreshed

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing



Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Ministries Departments and Central Secretariat - Complete Uncompressed Learning Session

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Original MCQs 1-36 - Broad Coverage

OM1. Which statement most accurately describes Article 73?

- A. Union executive power broadly follows Parliament's legislative field, subject to constitutional federal limits.
- B. It personally vests every decision in the President.
- C. It is the rule-making source for civil-service recruitment.
- D. It creates the Cabinet Secretariat.

Answer: A

Explanation: Article 73 defines executive reach, not the complete internal machinery. The other options collapse distinct legal sources, institutions or consequences and therefore fail the close-option test.

OM2. Which statement most accurately describes Articles 74 and 78?

- A. Article 78 allocates departments among Secretaries.
- B. Article 74 establishes aid and advice; Article 78 imposes Prime Ministerial communication and information duties to the President.
- C. Article 78 creates Cabinet Committees.
- D. Article 74 makes the PMO a constitutional body.

Answer: B

Explanation: The provisions govern the parliamentary executive relationship. The other options collapse distinct legal sources, institutions or consequences and therefore fail the close-option test.

OM3. Which statement most accurately describes Allocation versus Transaction Rules?

- A. AoB prescribes only Cabinet meeting procedure.
- B. AoB and ToB are rules under Article 309.
- C. AoB identifies who handles a subject; ToB prescribes how consultation, disposal and escalation occur.
- D. ToB permanently fixes ministry names.

Answer: C

Explanation: Both arise under Article 77(3) but answer different questions. The other options collapse distinct legal sources, institutions or consequences and therefore fail the close-option test.

OM4. Which statement most accurately describes ministry and department?

- A. A department is always a statutory corporation.
- B. A portfolio and department are synonyms.
- C. Every ministry has exactly one department.
- D. A ministry is the broader political-administrative unit; a department is an allocated subject unit generally headed administratively by a Secretary.

Answer: D

Explanation: Political charge, allocated business and administrative structure must be separated. The other options collapse distinct legal sources, institutions or consequences and therefore fail the close-option test.

OM5. Which statement most accurately describes Minister and Secretary?

- A. The Minister supplies democratic direction and parliamentary answerability; the Secretary supplies administration, advice, legality and continuity.
- B. The Secretary is a parallel political executive.

- C. Ministerial responsibility erases official accountability.
- D. The Minister cannot seek professional advice.

Answer: A

Explanation: Responsive neutrality requires candid advice and lawful implementation. The other options collapse distinct legal sources, institutions or consequences and therefore fail the close-option test.

OM6. Which statement most accurately describes Central Secretariat?

- A. It is another name for the Cabinet Secretariat.
- B. The Central Secretariat collectively supports policy, legislation, budgeting, coordination, monitoring and institutional memory.
- C. It performs only field delivery.
- D. It is a single constitutional office.

Answer: B

Explanation: It is collective policy machinery across departments. The other options collapse distinct legal sources, institutions or consequences and therefore fail the close-option test.

OM7. Which statement most accurately describes Cabinet Secretariat and PMO?

- A. Both are constitutional commissions.
- B. The PMO is custodian of Cabinet records by definition.
- C. The Cabinet Secretariat services collective Cabinet government; the PMO supports the Prime Minister directly.
- D. The Cabinet Secretary is a political minister.

Answer: C

Explanation: Different centre-of-government roles must not be collapsed. The other options collapse distinct legal sources, institutions or consequences and therefore fail the close-option test.

OM8. Which statement most accurately describes delegation and files?

- A. Every file must reach the Secretary.
- B. Oral approval permanently replaces record.
- C. Delegation removes ministerial accountability.
- D. Routine work should be disposed at the lowest competent delegated level with recorded authority, consultation and reasons.

Answer: D

Explanation: Delegation prevents apex overload while retaining traceability. The other options collapse distinct legal sources, institutions or consequences and therefore fail the close-option test.

OM9. Which statement most accurately describes attached and subordinate offices?

- A. Attached offices provide detailed executive/technical direction; subordinate offices commonly execute in the field.
- B. Both are independent constitutional bodies.
- C. Subordinate offices cannot exercise delegated statutory power.
- D. Attached offices necessarily adjudicate.

Answer: A

Explanation: Labels indicate administrative relation, not identical legal power. The other options collapse distinct legal sources, institutions or consequences and therefore fail the close-option test.

OM10. Which statement most accurately describes autonomous bodies CPSEs regulators?

- A. A CPSE is automatically a constitutional body.
- B. Autonomous bodies, CPSEs and regulators have distinct instruments, purposes and accountability regimes.
- C. All are departments under Article 77.

- D. A ministry may override any statutory regulator order.

Answer: B

Explanation: Stewardship and ownership do not erase legal autonomy. The other options collapse distinct legal sources, institutions or consequences and therefore fail the close-option test.

OM11. Which statement most accurately describes oversight?

- A. Committee recommendations are judicial decrees.
- B. RTI removes every lawful exemption.
- C. Parliamentary committees, demands for grants, CAG, RTI, courts and vigilance provide different accountability routes.
- D. CAG directly dismisses officials.

Answer: C

Explanation: Political, financial, transparency and legal controls are complementary. The other options collapse distinct legal sources, institutions or consequences and therefore fail the close-option test.

OM12. Which statement most accurately describes reorganisation?

- A. Every reorganisation needs Article 368.
- B. The number of ministries is constitutionally fixed.
- C. A renamed ministry automatically amends all statutes.
- D. Ministries and departments may be renamed, merged or split through the business-rule framework, subject to statutes and transition requirements.

Answer: D

Explanation: Current organisation is notification-sensitive and must be dated. The other options collapse distinct legal sources, institutions or consequences and therefore fail the close-option test.

OM13. Which is the safest UPSC distinction concerning Article 73?

- A. Union executive power broadly follows Parliament's legislative field, subject to constitutional federal limits.
- B. It personally vests every decision in the President.
- C. It creates the Cabinet Secretariat.
- D. It is the rule-making source for civil-service recruitment.

Answer: A

Explanation: Article 73 defines executive reach, not the complete internal machinery. The other options collapse distinct legal sources, institutions or consequences and therefore fail the close-option test.

OM14. Which is the safest UPSC distinction concerning Articles 74 and 78?

- A. Article 78 allocates departments among Secretaries.
- B. Article 74 establishes aid and advice; Article 78 imposes Prime Ministerial communication and information duties to the President.
- C. Article 78 creates Cabinet Committees.
- D. Article 74 makes the PMO a constitutional body.

Answer: B

Explanation: The provisions govern the parliamentary executive relationship. The other options collapse distinct legal sources, institutions or consequences and therefore fail the close-option test.

OM15. Which is the safest UPSC distinction concerning Allocation versus Transaction Rules?

- A. ToB permanently fixes ministry names.
- B. AoB prescribes only Cabinet meeting procedure.
- C. AoB identifies who handles a subject; ToB prescribes how consultation, disposal and escalation occur.
- D. AoB and ToB are rules under Article 309.

Answer: C

Explanation: Both arise under Article 77(3) but answer different questions. The other options collapse distinct legal sources, institutions or consequences and therefore fail the close-option test.

OM16. Which is the safest UPSC distinction concerning ministry and department?

- A. Every ministry has exactly one department.
- B. A department is always a statutory corporation.
- C. A portfolio and department are synonyms.
- D. A ministry is the broader political-administrative unit; a department is an allocated subject unit generally headed administratively by a Secretary.

Answer: D

Explanation: Political charge, allocated business and administrative structure must be separated. The other options collapse distinct legal sources, institutions or consequences and therefore fail the close-option test.

OM17. Which is the safest UPSC distinction concerning Minister and Secretary?

- A. The Minister supplies democratic direction and parliamentary answerability; the Secretary supplies administration, advice, legality and continuity.
- B. The Minister cannot seek professional advice.
- C. Ministerial responsibility erases official accountability.
- D. The Secretary is a parallel political executive.

Answer: A

Explanation: Responsive neutrality requires candid advice and lawful implementation. The other options collapse distinct legal sources, institutions or consequences and therefore fail the close-option test.

OM18. Which is the safest UPSC distinction concerning Central Secretariat?

- A. It performs only field delivery.
- B. The Central Secretariat collectively supports policy, legislation, budgeting, coordination, monitoring and institutional memory.
- C. It is a single constitutional office.
- D. It is another name for the Cabinet Secretariat.

Answer: B

Explanation: It is collective policy machinery across departments. The other options collapse distinct legal sources, institutions or consequences and therefore fail the close-option test.

OM19. Which is the safest UPSC distinction concerning Cabinet Secretariat and PMO?

- A. The PMO is custodian of Cabinet records by definition.
- B. Both are constitutional commissions.
- C. The Cabinet Secretariat services collective Cabinet government; the PMO supports the Prime Minister directly.
- D. The Cabinet Secretary is a political minister.

Answer: C

Explanation: Different centre-of-government roles must not be collapsed. The other options collapse distinct legal sources, institutions or consequences and therefore fail the close-option test.

OM20. Which is the safest UPSC distinction concerning delegation and files?

- A. Oral approval permanently replaces record.
- B. Delegation removes ministerial accountability.
- C. Every file must reach the Secretary.
- D. Routine work should be disposed at the lowest competent delegated level with recorded authority, consultation and reasons.

Answer: D

Explanation: Delegation prevents apex overload while retaining traceability. The other options collapse distinct legal sources, institutions or consequences and therefore fail the close-option test.

OM21. Which is the safest UPSC distinction concerning attached and subordinate offices?

- A. Attached offices provide detailed executive/technical direction; subordinate offices commonly execute in the field.
- B. Both are independent constitutional bodies.
- C. Subordinate offices cannot exercise delegated statutory power.
- D. Attached offices necessarily adjudicate.

Answer: A

Explanation: Labels indicate administrative relation, not identical legal power. The other options collapse distinct legal sources, institutions or consequences and therefore fail the close-option test.

OM22. Which is the safest UPSC distinction concerning autonomous bodies CPSEs regulators?

- A. A ministry may override any statutory regulator order.
- B. Autonomous bodies, CPSEs and regulators have distinct instruments, purposes and accountability regimes.
- C. All are departments under Article 77.
- D. A CPSE is automatically a constitutional body.

Answer: B

Explanation: Stewardship and ownership do not erase legal autonomy. The other options collapse distinct legal sources, institutions or consequences and therefore fail the close-option test.

OM23. Which is the safest UPSC distinction concerning oversight?

- A. Committee recommendations are judicial decrees.
- B. RTI removes every lawful exemption.
- C. Parliamentary committees, demands for grants, CAG, RTI, courts and vigilance provide different accountability routes.
- D. CAG directly dismisses officials.

Answer: C

Explanation: Political, financial, transparency and legal controls are complementary. The other options collapse distinct legal sources, institutions or consequences and therefore fail the close-option test.

OM24. Which is the safest UPSC distinction concerning reorganisation?

- A. A renamed ministry automatically amends all statutes.
- B. Every reorganisation needs Article 368.
- C. The number of ministries is constitutionally fixed.
- D. Ministries and departments may be renamed, merged or split through the business-rule framework, subject to statutes and transition requirements.

Answer: D

Explanation: Current organisation is notification-sensitive and must be dated. The other options collapse distinct legal sources, institutions or consequences and therefore fail the close-option test.

OM25. A candidate makes a close-option error about Article 73. Which correction is most accurate?

- A. Union executive power broadly follows Parliament's legislative field, subject to constitutional federal limits.
- B. It is the rule-making source for civil-service recruitment.
- C. It creates the Cabinet Secretariat.
- D. It personally vests every decision in the President.

Answer: A

Explanation: Article 73 defines executive reach, not the complete internal machinery. The other options collapse distinct legal sources, institutions or consequences and therefore fail the close-option test.

OM26. A candidate makes a close-option error about Articles 74 and 78. Which correction is most accurate?

- A. Article 78 creates Cabinet Committees.
- B. Article 74 establishes aid and advice; Article 78 imposes Prime Ministerial communication and information duties to the President.
- C. Article 78 allocates departments among Secretaries.
- D. Article 74 makes the PMO a constitutional body.

Answer: B

Explanation: The provisions govern the parliamentary executive relationship. The other options collapse distinct legal sources, institutions or consequences and therefore fail the close-option test.

OM27. A candidate makes a close-option error about Allocation versus Transaction Rules. Which correction is most accurate?

- A. ToB permanently fixes ministry names.
- B. AoB prescribes only Cabinet meeting procedure.
- C. AoB identifies who handles a subject; ToB prescribes how consultation, disposal and escalation occur.
- D. AoB and ToB are rules under Article 309.

Answer: C

Explanation: Both arise under Article 77(3) but answer different questions. The other options collapse distinct legal sources, institutions or consequences and therefore fail the close-option test.

OM28. A candidate makes a close-option error about ministry and department. Which correction is most accurate?

- A. Every ministry has exactly one department.
- B. A portfolio and department are synonyms.
- C. A department is always a statutory corporation.
- D. A ministry is the broader political-administrative unit; a department is an allocated subject unit generally headed administratively by a Secretary.

Answer: D

Explanation: Political charge, allocated business and administrative structure must be separated. The other options collapse distinct legal sources, institutions or consequences and therefore fail the close-option test.

OM29. A candidate makes a close-option error about Minister and Secretary. Which correction is most accurate?

- A. The Minister supplies democratic direction and parliamentary answerability; the Secretary supplies administration, advice, legality and continuity.
- B. Ministerial responsibility erases official accountability.
- C. The Secretary is a parallel political executive.
- D. The Minister cannot seek professional advice.

Answer: A

Explanation: Responsive neutrality requires candid advice and lawful implementation. The other options collapse distinct legal sources, institutions or consequences and therefore fail the close-option test.

OM30. A candidate makes a close-option error about Central Secretariat. Which correction is most accurate?

- A. It performs only field delivery.
- B. The Central Secretariat collectively supports policy, legislation, budgeting, coordination, monitoring and institutional memory.

- C. It is a single constitutional office.
- D. It is another name for the Cabinet Secretariat.

Answer: B

Explanation: It is collective policy machinery across departments. The other options collapse distinct legal sources, institutions or consequences and therefore fail the close-option test.

OM31. A candidate makes a close-option error about Cabinet Secretariat and PMO. Which correction is most accurate?

- A. Both are constitutional commissions.
- B. The Cabinet Secretary is a political minister.
- C. The Cabinet Secretariat services collective Cabinet government; the PMO supports the Prime Minister directly.
- D. The PMO is custodian of Cabinet records by definition.

Answer: C

Explanation: Different centre-of-government roles must not be collapsed. The other options collapse distinct legal sources, institutions or consequences and therefore fail the close-option test.

OM32. A candidate makes a close-option error about delegation and files. Which correction is most accurate?

- A. Every file must reach the Secretary.
- B. Oral approval permanently replaces record.
- C. Delegation removes ministerial accountability.
- D. Routine work should be disposed at the lowest competent delegated level with recorded authority, consultation and reasons.

Answer: D

Explanation: Delegation prevents apex overload while retaining traceability. The other options collapse distinct legal sources, institutions or consequences and therefore fail the close-option test.

OM33. A candidate makes a close-option error about attached and subordinate offices. Which correction is most accurate?

- A. Attached offices provide detailed executive/technical direction; subordinate offices commonly execute in the field.
- B. Both are independent constitutional bodies.
- C. Subordinate offices cannot exercise delegated statutory power.
- D. Attached offices necessarily adjudicate.

Answer: A

Explanation: Labels indicate administrative relation, not identical legal power. The other options collapse distinct legal sources, institutions or consequences and therefore fail the close-option test.

OM34. A candidate makes a close-option error about autonomous bodies CPSEs regulators. Which correction is most accurate?

- A. A CPSE is automatically a constitutional body.
- B. Autonomous bodies, CPSEs and regulators have distinct instruments, purposes and accountability regimes.
- C. All are departments under Article 77.
- D. A ministry may override any statutory regulator order.

Answer: B

Explanation: Stewardship and ownership do not erase legal autonomy. The other options collapse distinct legal sources, institutions or consequences and therefore fail the close-option test.

OM35. A candidate makes a close-option error about oversight. Which correction is most accurate?

- A. RTI removes every lawful exemption.

- B. Committee recommendations are judicial decrees.
- C. Parliamentary committees, demands for grants, CAG, RTI, courts and vigilance provide different accountability routes.
- D. CAG directly dismisses officials.

Answer: C

Explanation: Political, financial, transparency and legal controls are complementary. The other options collapse distinct legal sources, institutions or consequences and therefore fail the close-option test.

OM36. A candidate makes a close-option error about reorganisation. Which correction is most accurate?

- A. A renamed ministry automatically amends all statutes.
- B. The number of ministries is constitutionally fixed.
- C. Every reorganisation needs Article 368.
- D. Ministries and departments may be renamed, merged or split through the business-rule framework, subject to statutes and transition requirements.

Answer: D

Explanation: Current organisation is notification-sensitive and must be dated. The other options collapse distinct legal sources, institutions or consequences and therefore fail the close-option test.

Remedial MCQs 1-12 - Common Error Repair

RM1. Which statement best repairs a recurring error about Article 73?

- A. Union executive power broadly follows Parliament's legislative field, subject to constitutional federal limits.
- B. It personally vests every decision in the President.
- C. It creates the Cabinet Secretariat.
- D. It is the rule-making source for civil-service recruitment.

Answer: A

Remedial explanation: Article 73 defines executive reach, not the complete internal machinery. Write the governing source, then the mechanism, and finally the limitation before choosing an option.

RM2. Which statement best repairs a recurring error about Articles 74 and 78?

- A. Article 78 allocates departments among Secretaries.
- B. Article 74 establishes aid and advice; Article 78 imposes Prime Ministerial communication and information duties to the President.
- C. Article 74 makes the PMO a constitutional body.
- D. Article 78 creates Cabinet Committees.

Answer: B

Remedial explanation: The provisions govern the parliamentary executive relationship. Write the governing source, then the mechanism, and finally the limitation before choosing an option.

RM3. Which statement best repairs a recurring error about Allocation versus Transaction Rules?

- A. AoB and ToB are rules under Article 309.
- B. ToB permanently fixes ministry names.
- C. AoB identifies who handles a subject; ToB prescribes how consultation, disposal and escalation occur.
- D. AoB prescribes only Cabinet meeting procedure.

Answer: C

Remedial explanation: Both arise under Article 77(3) but answer different questions. Write the governing source, then the mechanism, and finally the limitation before choosing an option.

RM4. Which statement best repairs a recurring error about ministry and department?

- A. A department is always a statutory corporation.

- B. A portfolio and department are synonyms.
- C. Every ministry has exactly one department.
- D. A ministry is the broader political-administrative unit; a department is an allocated subject unit generally headed administratively by a Secretary.

Answer: D

Remedial explanation: Political charge, allocated business and administrative structure must be separated. Write the governing source, then the mechanism, and finally the limitation before choosing an option.

RM5. Which statement best repairs a recurring error about Minister and Secretary?

- A. The Minister supplies democratic direction and parliamentary answerability; the Secretary supplies administration, advice, legality and continuity.
- B. Ministerial responsibility erases official accountability.
- C. The Minister cannot seek professional advice.
- D. The Secretary is a parallel political executive.

Answer: A

Remedial explanation: Responsive neutrality requires candid advice and lawful implementation. Write the governing source, then the mechanism, and finally the limitation before choosing an option.

RM6. Which statement best repairs a recurring error about Central Secretariat?

- A. It is another name for the Cabinet Secretariat.
- B. The Central Secretariat collectively supports policy, legislation, budgeting, coordination, monitoring and institutional memory.
- C. It performs only field delivery.
- D. It is a single constitutional office.

Answer: B

Remedial explanation: It is collective policy machinery across departments. Write the governing source, then the mechanism, and finally the limitation before choosing an option.

RM7. Which statement best repairs a recurring error about Cabinet Secretariat and PMO?

- A. The Cabinet Secretary is a political minister.
- B. Both are constitutional commissions.
- C. The Cabinet Secretariat services collective Cabinet government; the PMO supports the Prime Minister directly.
- D. The PMO is custodian of Cabinet records by definition.

Answer: C

Remedial explanation: Different centre-of-government roles must not be collapsed. Write the governing source, then the mechanism, and finally the limitation before choosing an option.

RM8. Which statement best repairs a recurring error about delegation and files?

- A. Delegation removes ministerial accountability.
- B. Every file must reach the Secretary.
- C. Oral approval permanently replaces record.
- D. Routine work should be disposed at the lowest competent delegated level with recorded authority, consultation and reasons.

Answer: D

Remedial explanation: Delegation prevents apex overload while retaining traceability. Write the governing source, then the mechanism, and finally the limitation before choosing an option.

RM9. Which statement best repairs a recurring error about attached and subordinate offices?

- A. Attached offices provide detailed executive/technical direction; subordinate offices commonly execute in the field.

- B. Attached offices necessarily adjudicate.
- C. Both are independent constitutional bodies.
- D. Subordinate offices cannot exercise delegated statutory power.

Answer: A

Remedial explanation: Labels indicate administrative relation, not identical legal power. Write the governing source, then the mechanism, and finally the limitation before choosing an option.

RM10. Which statement best repairs a recurring error about autonomous bodies CPSEs regulators?

- A. A CPSE is automatically a constitutional body.
- B. Autonomous bodies, CPSEs and regulators have distinct instruments, purposes and accountability regimes.
- C. All are departments under Article 77.
- D. A ministry may override any statutory regulator order.

Answer: B

Remedial explanation: Stewardship and ownership do not erase legal autonomy. Write the governing source, then the mechanism, and finally the limitation before choosing an option.

RM11. Which statement best repairs a recurring error about oversight?

- A. RTI removes every lawful exemption.
- B. Committee recommendations are judicial decrees.
- C. Parliamentary committees, demands for grants, CAG, RTI, courts and vigilance provide different accountability routes.
- D. CAG directly dismisses officials.

Answer: C

Remedial explanation: Political, financial, transparency and legal controls are complementary. Write the governing source, then the mechanism, and finally the limitation before choosing an option.

RM12. Which statement best repairs a recurring error about reorganisation?

- A. The number of ministries is constitutionally fixed.
- B. A renamed ministry automatically amends all statutes.
- C. Every reorganisation needs Article 368.
- D. Ministries and departments may be renamed, merged or split through the business-rule framework, subject to statutes and transition requirements.

Answer: D

Remedial explanation: Current organisation is notification-sensitive and must be dated. Write the governing source, then the mechanism, and finally the limitation before choosing an option.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Verified and Supporting PYQs with Model Solutions

Verified direct PYQ 1 - 2025 Prelims GS-I Q57

Question: With reference to India, consider the pairs: National Automotive Board-Ministry of Commerce and Industry; Coir Board-Ministry of Heavy Industries; National Centre for Trade Information-Ministry of Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises. How many are correctly matched?

Directive: Objective close-option classification · **Marks:** 2 · **Word limit:** objective

Model solution

Opening: With reference to India, consider the pairs: National Automotive Board-Ministry of Commerce and Industry; Coir Board-Ministry of Heavy Industries; National Centre for Trade Information-Ministry of Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises. The answer must respond to the directive **Objective close-option classification** rather than merely

describe the topic.

- **Claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification:** The official Set-A key is D: none of the three displayed pairings is correct.
- **Claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification:** National Automotive Board belongs to the Heavy Industries subject field.
- **Claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification:** Coir Board belongs to the MSME subject field under its statutory/allocated business.
- **Claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification:** NCTI belongs to the Commerce and Industry subject field.
- **Claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification:** The method is to identify the parent statute/allocated subject, not infer from the name.

Conclusion: The strongest answer identifies the governing design, shows how it operates with named evidence, tests the counter-position and ends with a qualified institutional verdict.

Supporting routed PYQ 2 - 2020 GS-II Q7

Question: Suggest civil-service reforms required to strengthen democracy by improving institutional quality.

Directive: Suggest reforms · **Marks:** 10 · **Word limit:** 150

Model solution

Opening: Suggest civil-service reforms required to strengthen democracy by improving institutional quality. The answer must respond to the directive **Suggest reforms** rather than merely describe the topic.

- **Claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification:** Institutional quality depends on competent departments, recorded advice and lawful responsibility.
- **Claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification:** Minister-Secretary complementarity joins democratic direction to professional continuity.
- **Claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification:** Stable tenure, domain capability, delegation and field feedback reduce policy failure.
- **Claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification:** Digital files improve traceability only when authority and reasons remain clear.
- **Claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification:** Civil-service reform must be linked to departmental process, outcomes and parliamentary scrutiny.

Conclusion: The strongest answer identifies the governing design, shows how it operates with named evidence, tests the counter-position and ends with a qualified institutional verdict.

Supporting routed PYQ 3 - 2024 GS-II Q3

Question: The growth of cabinet system has practically resulted in the marginalisation of parliamentary supremacy. Elucidate.

Directive: Elucidate · **Marks:** 10 · **Word limit:** 150

Model solution

Opening: The growth of cabinet system has practically resulted in the marginalisation of parliamentary supremacy. The answer must respond to the directive **Elucidate** rather than merely describe the topic.

- **Claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification:** Ministries control policy information, drafting, delegated legislation and budget preparation.
- **Claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification:** Cabinet solidarity and party discipline can reduce independent legislative influence.
- **Claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification:** Questions, committees, demands for grants and audit remain constitutional correctives.
- **Claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification:** The claim concerns executive dominance, not British-style legal parliamentary sovereignty in India.

- **Claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification:** A balanced answer seeks stronger scrutiny without disabling responsible government.

Conclusion: The strongest answer identifies the governing design, shows how it operates with named evidence, tests the counter-position and ends with a qualified institutional verdict.

Original Solved Mains Practice

M1. Distinguish a ministry, department, secretariat and attached office in the Union Government.

Directive: Distinguish · **Marks:** 10 · **Suggested words:** 150

Demand decode: Define the exact institutional or doctrinal issue, answer the directive, use named constitutional/statutory/judicial evidence, include the strongest counterpoint and reach a qualified verdict.

Examiner opening: Distinguish a ministry, department, secretariat and attached office in the Union Government. The issue should be analysed through constitutional purpose, operating mechanism and enforceable limitation.

- **Articles 74 And 78 - claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification:** Article 74 establishes aid and advice; Article 78 imposes Prime Ministerial communication and information duties to the President. The provisions govern the parliamentary executive relationship.
- **Allocation Versus Transaction Rules - claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification:** AoB identifies who handles a subject; ToB prescribes how consultation, disposal and escalation occur. Both arise under Article 77(3) but answer different questions.
- **Ministry And Department - claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification:** A ministry is the broader political-administrative unit; a department is an allocated subject unit generally headed administratively by a Secretary. Political charge, allocated business and administrative structure must be separated.
- **Minister And Secretary - claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification:** The Minister supplies democratic direction and parliamentary answerability; the Secretary supplies administration, advice, legality and continuity. Responsive neutrality requires candid advice and lawful implementation.
- **Central Secretariat - claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification:** The Central Secretariat collectively supports policy, legislation, budgeting, coordination, monitoring and institutional memory. It is collective policy machinery across departments.

Counter-position: Institutional reform can improve accountability, but overbroad regulation may displace autonomy, federal choice, expertise or access. The answer must identify the exact trade-off rather than offer a generic reform list.

Conclusion: Prefer a calibrated design that preserves the institution's constitutional purpose while adding transparency, independence, reason-giving and judicially reviewable safeguards.

M2. Explain the constitutional and rules-of-business basis of Union ministries and departments.

Directive: Explain · **Marks:** 10 · **Suggested words:** 150

Demand decode: Define the exact institutional or doctrinal issue, answer the directive, use named constitutional/statutory/judicial evidence, include the strongest counterpoint and reach a qualified verdict.

Examiner opening: Explain the constitutional and rules-of-business basis of Union ministries and departments. The issue should be analysed through constitutional purpose, operating mechanism and enforceable limitation.

- **Allocation Versus Transaction Rules - claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification:** AoB identifies who handles a subject; ToB prescribes how consultation, disposal and escalation occur. Both arise under Article 77(3) but answer different questions.
- **Ministry And Department - claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification:** A ministry is the broader political-administrative unit; a department is an allocated subject unit generally headed administratively by a Secretary. Political charge, allocated business and administrative structure must be separated.
- **Minister And Secretary - claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification:** The Minister supplies democratic direction and parliamentary answerability; the Secretary supplies administration, advice, legality and continuity. Responsive neutrality requires candid advice and lawful implementation.
- **Central Secretariat - claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification:** The Central Secretariat collectively supports policy, legislation, budgeting, coordination, monitoring and institutional memory. It is collective policy

machinery across departments.

- **Cabinet Secretariat And Pmo - claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification:** The Cabinet Secretariat services collective Cabinet government; the PMO supports the Prime Minister directly. Different centre-of-government roles must not be collapsed.

Counter-position: Institutional reform can improve accountability, but overbroad regulation may displace autonomy, federal choice, expertise or access. The answer must identify the exact trade-off rather than offer a generic reform list.

Conclusion: Prefer a calibrated design that preserves the institution's constitutional purpose while adding transparency, independence, reason-giving and judicially reviewable safeguards.

M3. Examine the Minister-Secretary relationship as the hinge between democratic control and administrative continuity.

Directive: Examine · **Marks:** 15 · **Suggested words:** 250

Demand decode: Define the exact institutional or doctrinal issue, answer the directive, use named constitutional/statutory/judicial evidence, include the strongest counterpoint and reach a qualified verdict.

Examiner opening: Examine the Minister-Secretary relationship as the hinge between democratic control and administrative continuity. The issue should be analysed through constitutional purpose, operating mechanism and enforceable limitation.

- **Ministry And Department - claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification:** A ministry is the broader political-administrative unit; a department is an allocated subject unit generally headed administratively by a Secretary. Political charge, allocated business and administrative structure must be separated.
- **Minister And Secretary - claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification:** The Minister supplies democratic direction and parliamentary answerability; the Secretary supplies administration, advice, legality and continuity. Responsive neutrality requires candid advice and lawful implementation.
- **Central Secretariat - claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification:** The Central Secretariat collectively supports policy, legislation, budgeting, coordination, monitoring and institutional memory. It is collective policy machinery across departments.
- **Cabinet Secretariat And Pmo - claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification:** The Cabinet Secretariat services collective Cabinet government; the PMO supports the Prime Minister directly. Different centre-of-government roles must not be collapsed.
- **Delegation And Files - claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification:** Routine work should be disposed at the lowest competent delegated level with recorded authority, consultation and reasons. Delegation prevents apex overload while retaining traceability.

Counter-position: Institutional reform can improve accountability, but overbroad regulation may displace autonomy, federal choice, expertise or access. The answer must identify the exact trade-off rather than offer a generic reform list.

Conclusion: Prefer a calibrated design that preserves the institution's constitutional purpose while adding transparency, independence, reason-giving and judicially reviewable safeguards.

M4. Analyse how the Cabinet Secretariat secures inter-ministerial coordination without becoming a super-ministry.

Directive: Analyse · **Marks:** 15 · **Suggested words:** 250

Demand decode: Define the exact institutional or doctrinal issue, answer the directive, use named constitutional/statutory/judicial evidence, include the strongest counterpoint and reach a qualified verdict.

Examiner opening: Analyse how the Cabinet Secretariat secures inter-ministerial coordination without becoming a super-ministry. The issue should be analysed through constitutional purpose, operating mechanism and enforceable limitation.

- **Minister And Secretary - claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification:** The Minister supplies democratic direction and parliamentary answerability; the Secretary supplies administration, advice, legality and continuity. Responsive neutrality requires candid advice and lawful implementation.
- **Central Secretariat - claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification:** The Central Secretariat collectively supports policy, legislation, budgeting, coordination, monitoring and institutional memory. It is collective policy

machinery across departments.

- **Cabinet Secretariat And Pmo - claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification:** The Cabinet Secretariat services collective Cabinet government; the PMO supports the Prime Minister directly. Different centre-of-government roles must not be collapsed.
- **Delegation And Files - claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification:** Routine work should be disposed at the lowest competent delegated level with recorded authority, consultation and reasons. Delegation prevents apex overload while retaining traceability.
- **Attached And Subordinate Offices - claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification:** Attached offices provide detailed executive/technical direction; subordinate offices commonly execute in the field. Labels indicate administrative relation, not identical legal power.

Counter-position: Institutional reform can improve accountability, but overbroad regulation may displace autonomy, federal choice, expertise or access. The answer must identify the exact trade-off rather than offer a generic reform list.

Conclusion: Prefer a calibrated design that preserves the institution's constitutional purpose while adding transparency, independence, reason-giving and judicially reviewable safeguards.

M5. Discuss the functions, internal process and accountability architecture of the Central Secretariat.

Directive: Discuss · **Marks:** 20 · **Suggested words:** 300

Demand decode: Define the exact institutional or doctrinal issue, answer the directive, use named constitutional/statutory/judicial evidence, include the strongest counterpoint and reach a qualified verdict.

Examiner opening: Discuss the functions, internal process and accountability architecture of the Central Secretariat. The issue should be analysed through constitutional purpose, operating mechanism and enforceable limitation.

- **Central Secretariat - claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification:** The Central Secretariat collectively supports policy, legislation, budgeting, coordination, monitoring and institutional memory. It is collective policy machinery across departments.
- **Cabinet Secretariat And Pmo - claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification:** The Cabinet Secretariat services collective Cabinet government; the PMO supports the Prime Minister directly. Different centre-of-government roles must not be collapsed.
- **Delegation And Files - claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification:** Routine work should be disposed at the lowest competent delegated level with recorded authority, consultation and reasons. Delegation prevents apex overload while retaining traceability.
- **Attached And Subordinate Offices - claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification:** Attached offices provide detailed executive/technical direction; subordinate offices commonly execute in the field. Labels indicate administrative relation, not identical legal power.
- **Autonomous Bodies Cpses Regulators - claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification:** Autonomous bodies, CPSEs and regulators have distinct instruments, purposes and accountability regimes. Stewardship and ownership do not erase legal autonomy.

Counter-position: Institutional reform can improve accountability, but overbroad regulation may displace autonomy, federal choice, expertise or access. The answer must identify the exact trade-off rather than offer a generic reform list.

Conclusion: Prefer a calibrated design that preserves the institution's constitutional purpose while adding transparency, independence, reason-giving and judicially reviewable safeguards.

M6. Critically evaluate centralisation, silos and delegation in the Union machinery of government.

Directive: Critically evaluate · **Marks:** 20 · **Suggested words:** 300

Demand decode: Define the exact institutional or doctrinal issue, answer the directive, use named constitutional/statutory/judicial evidence, include the strongest counterpoint and reach a qualified verdict.

Examiner opening: Critically evaluate centralisation, silos and delegation in the Union machinery of government. The issue should be analysed through constitutional purpose, operating mechanism and enforceable limitation.

- **Cabinet Secretariat And Pmo - claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification:** The Cabinet Secretariat services collective Cabinet government; the PMO supports the Prime Minister directly. Different centre-of-government roles must not be collapsed.

- **Delegation And Files - claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification:** Routine work should be disposed at the lowest competent delegated level with recorded authority, consultation and reasons. Delegation prevents apex overload while retaining traceability.
- **Attached And Subordinate Offices - claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification:** Attached offices provide detailed executive/technical direction; subordinate offices commonly execute in the field. Labels indicate administrative relation, not identical legal power.
- **Autonomous Bodies Cpses Regulators - claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification:** Autonomous bodies, CPSEs and regulators have distinct instruments, purposes and accountability regimes. Stewardship and ownership do not erase legal autonomy.
- **Oversight - claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification:** Parliamentary committees, demands for grants, CAG, RTI, courts and vigilance provide different accountability routes. Political, financial, transparency and legal controls are complementary.

Counter-position: Institutional reform can improve accountability, but overbroad regulation may displace autonomy, federal choice, expertise or access. The answer must identify the exact trade-off rather than offer a generic reform list.

Conclusion: Prefer a calibrated design that preserves the institution's constitutional purpose while adding transparency, independence, reason-giving and judicially reviewable safeguards.

M7. Assess the role and limits of mission-mode units, digital files and lateral expertise in departmental government.

Directive: Assess · **Marks:** 15 · **Suggested words:** 250

Demand decode: Define the exact institutional or doctrinal issue, answer the directive, use named constitutional/statutory/judicial evidence, include the strongest counterpoint and reach a qualified verdict.

Examiner opening: Assess the role and limits of mission-mode units, digital files and lateral expertise in departmental government. The issue should be analysed through constitutional purpose, operating mechanism and enforceable limitation.

- **Delegation And Files - claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification:** Routine work should be disposed at the lowest competent delegated level with recorded authority, consultation and reasons. Delegation prevents apex overload while retaining traceability.
- **Attached And Subordinate Offices - claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification:** Attached offices provide detailed executive/technical direction; subordinate offices commonly execute in the field. Labels indicate administrative relation, not identical legal power.
- **Autonomous Bodies Cpses Regulators - claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification:** Autonomous bodies, CPSEs and regulators have distinct instruments, purposes and accountability regimes. Stewardship and ownership do not erase legal autonomy.
- **Oversight - claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification:** Parliamentary committees, demands for grants, CAG, RTI, courts and vigilance provide different accountability routes. Political, financial, transparency and legal controls are complementary.
- **Reorganisation - claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification:** Ministries and departments may be renamed, merged or split through the business-rule framework, subject to statutes and transition requirements. Current organisation is notification-sensitive and must be dated.

Counter-position: Institutional reform can improve accountability, but overbroad regulation may displace autonomy, federal choice, expertise or access. The answer must identify the exact trade-off rather than offer a generic reform list.

Conclusion: Prefer a calibrated design that preserves the institution's constitutional purpose while adding transparency, independence, reason-giving and judicially reviewable safeguards.

M8. Propose a reform framework for reorganising ministries while preserving statutory continuity and accountability.

Directive: Propose · **Marks:** 20 · **Suggested words:** 300

Demand decode: Define the exact institutional or doctrinal issue, answer the directive, use named constitutional/statutory/judicial evidence, include the strongest counterpoint and reach a qualified verdict.

Examiner opening: Propose a reform framework for reorganising ministries while preserving statutory continuity and accountability. The issue should be analysed through constitutional purpose, operating mechanism and enforceable limitation.

- **Attached And Subordinate Offices - claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification:** Attached offices provide detailed executive/technical direction; subordinate offices commonly execute in the field. Labels indicate administrative relation, not identical legal power.
- **Autonomous Bodies Cpses Regulators - claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification:** Autonomous bodies, CPSEs and regulators have distinct instruments, purposes and accountability regimes. Stewardship and ownership do not erase legal autonomy.
- **Oversight - claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification:** Parliamentary committees, demands for grants, CAG, RTI, courts and vigilance provide different accountability routes. Political, financial, transparency and legal controls are complementary.
- **Reorganisation - claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification:** Ministries and departments may be renamed, merged or split through the business-rule framework, subject to statutes and transition requirements. Current organisation is notification-sensitive and must be dated.
- **Article 73 - claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification:** Union executive power broadly follows Parliament's legislative field, subject to constitutional federal limits. Article 73 defines executive reach, not the complete internal machinery.

Counter-position: Institutional reform can improve accountability, but overbroad regulation may displace autonomy, federal choice, expertise or access. The answer must identify the exact trade-off rather than offer a generic reform list.

Conclusion: Prefer a calibrated design that preserves the institution's constitutional purpose while adding transparency, independence, reason-giving and judicially reviewable safeguards.